

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 397

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Sondra Denise Keys-Wade.

WHEREAS, we were greatly saddened to learn of the untimely passing of our friend and former colleague Sondra Denise Keys-Wade; and

WHEREAS, Sondra Keys-Wade was an extraordinary individual who personified excellence, success, and service; she approached life lovingly and faced daily living with fierce optimism and was the epitome of God's true and faithful servant; and

WHEREAS, born on June 11, 1974, Ms. Keys-Wade was the daughter of Kay Miller Cook and David Lee Keys, Sr.; she attended Memphis City Schools elementary and secondary schools and was the first homecoming queen at John P. Freeman Junior High; and

WHEREAS, after graduating from Central High School, Sondra Keys-Wade attended Dillard University before transferring to the University of Memphis, where she was a member of two honor societies and a student delegate to the Tennessee Black Legislative Caucus Retreat; and

WHEREAS, she developed an interest in and love for politics early in life and served as an intern to Lois DeBerry, State of Tennessee Representative for District 91 and former Speaker Pro Tempore of the Tennessee House of Representatives; she also volunteered with the Clinton/Gore 1996 presidential campaign; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Keys-Wade earned her Juris Doctor degree from Vanderbilt University School of Law, receiving the Bennett Douglas Bell Memorial Award upon graduation; during her time at Vanderbilt, she studied abroad at Cambridge University in England, volunteered with the Juvenile Practice and Legal Aid clinics, and served on the Faculty-Student Relations Committee; and

WHEREAS, following graduation, Sondra Keys-Wade returned home to Memphis, and her professional path continued as Assistant City Attorney with the City of Memphis and then as an associate and lobbyist with the Harold Ford Group; she later accepted the position of Regional Manager for the Tennessee Human Rights Commission, an independent State agency that investigates allegations of discrimination for State agencies; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Keys-Wade returned to Nashville, where she joined the General Assembly's Office of Legal Services, in which position she gained the respect and trust of legislators and staff on Capitol Hill; she thereafter resumed private practice with one of the nation's leading law firms, Baker, Donelson, Bearman Caldwell & Berkowitz, working as a government relations attorney in the firm's State Public Policy Group; and

WHEREAS, as a consultant at Anderson Consulting, LLC, she developed and implemented comprehensive legislative, administrative, and regulatory strategies; she also served as Director of Government Affairs for Stand for Children, representing its interests before state and local public policy groups, and her final career calling brought her to Middle Tennessee State University's Office of General Counsel, where she worked in the position of Assistant General Counsel; and

WHEREAS, throughout her career, her professional affiliations included membership in the Tennessee Bar Association, the Napier-Looby Bar Association, the Vanderbilt University Alumni Association, and the Tennessee Alliance of Black Lawyers; she was a gubernatorial appointee to the Tennessee Department of Human Services Board of Appeals and a member of the Tennessee Bar Association Leadership Law Class of 2011; and

WHEREAS, ever focused on community service, Sondra Keys-Wade volunteered her time on the Board of Directors for the Nashville Conflict Resolution Center, and she was a proud member of 100 Black Women of Middle Tennessee; she served on the Grants Review

Committee of the Susan G. Komen Greater Nashville Chapter, the Lutheran Women's Missionary League, and the Full Circle Healthy Community Coalition as secretary; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Keys-Wade was a woman of abiding faith, accepting her Lord and Savior Jesus Christ early in life and proudly serving as a member and volunteer at Mount Zion Baptist Church; and

WHEREAS, a beloved daughter, sister, spouse, mother, and friend, Sondra Keys-Wade was wholly devoted to her family and always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, she will be mourned but fondly remembered by her husband, Dr. Frank D. Wade; her bonus daughter, Katherine Josephine Wade; her brother, David Lee (Justin) Keys, Jr.; her niece, Kaley J. Brown; her nephew, Bryson M. Coffey; her stepmother, Cheryl Keys; her aunts, Janet M. (Timothy) Evans, Denise K. (Calvin) Johnson, Demetrice K. Rufus, and Gail M. Taylor; her uncles, Larry McKissick and Dandridge Keys; her great-uncle, Clarence Jordan; and a host of cousins, family, and friends; and

WHEREAS, in addition to her parents, she was preceded in death by her sister, Jana Marie Keys; and

WHEREAS, Sondra Keys-Wade leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all her chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we honor the life and legacy of this beautiful, on the inside and out, kind, caring, selfless, graceful, thoughtful, fierce, brilliant, hilarious, and faith-filled human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Sondra Denise Keys-

Wade, reflecting fondly upon her impeccable character and her stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we extend our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Ms. Keys-Wade.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.